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The Long MARCH

2003 The first T20 match is played between Hampshire and Sussex.

2005 Australia and New Zealand play the first T20 international.

2006 India play their first T20 against South Africa and beat them.

AUGUST 2007 Subhash Chandra launches the Indian Cricket League.

SEPTEMBER 2007 BCCI launches IPL.

SEPTEMBER 2007 India wins the first ICC World T20 in Johannesburg.

FEBRUARY 2008 Players are auctioned for IPL.

APRIL 2008 The first IPL event is a success.

JUNE 2009 Pakistan wins the second ICC World T20 in London.

THE T20 format doesn't allow you to settle down. It's not like the Test or ODI matches where you can spend time getting in.

M.S. DHONI,
INDIAN CAPTAIN

thought, 'Christ, can this guy whack the ball'. Morgan must know his finances could double overnight if he carries on playing well in T20.

As this game has moved on from England, what took us all by surprise were just how the scores have climbed every season. In the beginning, if someone asked me what would have been a decent T20 score, I would have said about 140. Today if you score 140 you lose more games than you win. You now get scores towards 200 now and at Centurion last month, South Africa scored 241 versus England. It is as if people can hit the ball out of the ground if they want to.

Teams now select batsmen who can just come in, pick up their bats and try and hit the bowlers for a six. Ten years ago, if you told someone that a batsman would get down on one knee to a fast bowler, flick the ball over the wicket-keeper's head and do it nearly every time, you would have been certified. T20 is a young man's game because you've got to be quick on your feet, think and adapt very fast. Thinking 'this is how I play and this is how I've always played' is writing a T20 pink slip.

A few commentators say they hate T20 because it's not for bowlers, they moan 'oh, you might as well put a bowling machine'. I don't agree. T20 cricket is about survival of the fittest in its first few years in international competition. Bowlers have adjusted and the unorthodox ones like Lasitha Malinga, Ajantha Mendis and Harbhajan Singh, who are spinning it both ways, are successful, they are the kind who win matches. The kind who have learnt to bowl yorkers, reverse the ball, bowl the *doosras* that spin the other way. The best way of stopping the opposition from getting to 200 is by getting wickets and these fellows make a very strong statement with their T20 performances. Pakistan for one has won 21 out of 27 T20 internationals and not because of their batting, but their bowling. England struggled because they do not have genuine wicket-takers. They have the containment men, but other than Andrew Flintoff, no genuine wicket-takers.

What T20 has also done is to threaten to almost shift the earth in the international game. The IPL may only be two years old, but its aftershocks are already being felt. It's a massive phenomena in India which only got

Since then, cricket has caught on to the format with a big appetite: the two World T20 events, South Africa 2007 and England 2009, have been the best tournaments I have worked on. Along with, of course, the Ashes in England. T20 that brings a younger audience into domestic cricket in every country. That is good for cricket, that's good for the game's finances in the long term. Cricket needs younger people coming in, families returning to it as an outing. It all adds up.

However, I don't think that the England and Wales Cricket Board or the International Cricket Council have prospered financially because of T20. But I'm sure that the Board of Control for Cricket in India has, because no matter what is happening elsewhere in the world, the Indian Premier League (IPL) which began in 2008, has certainly changed the rules of the game. It made an impact on players' finances more than any other event in cricket after the Kerry Packer series.

In the old days, if you won a tournament for Essex, you would get a £5,000 bonus at the end of the year with your pay packet. Now if you win a T20 tournament, you could be off to the Champions League and have a shot at a pot of gold. There are now lucrative deals to be had, IPL deals waiting. I'm sure if any IPL teams would have watched England's Eoin Morgan batting in South Africa, they would have sat up and